

Trigger Library

Sixteen public signals that a commercial building might be worth contacting now, ranked by what they actually tell you.

The rule that governs all of them

A trigger is an event, not a conclusion.

You saw a permit filed. You did not see their cleaning contract.

State the event, say what you do, and offer. Never state what you think the event means. Buyers can tell — everyone guessing at them sounds identical, and someone who states a checkable fact sounds like a person who did the work.

Every trigger needs a source and a date, or it scores zero regardless of type. Unsourced triggers are how invented claims get into emails.

The four tiers

The tier tells you *what kind of thing you know*, which matters more than how exciting it sounds.

Tier	What it means	Score
1 • Buying event	They have said, in public, that they are buying	5
2 • Facility event	A building changed in a way that creates a cleaning need	4
3 • Organizational event	The organization changed in a way that may put vendors up for review	3
4 • Secondary signal	Activity. Not evidence of a cleaning need	1

Modifiers: +1 a second independent trigger • +1 if under 30 days old • -2 past its window • **0 if source or date is missing**. Cap at 5.

Tier 1 breaks ties. A boosted facility event can reach 5, but a stated solicitation is a different kind of knowledge, and when two accounts tie you work the Tier 1.

Tier 1 • Buying events

The only triggers where the building has told you it is buying. Everything else on this page is inference, however good.

1. Janitorial contract out to bid

A school district, municipality, county, hospital or housing authority publishes a solicitation for cleaning services.

Where	State, county, city and school-district procurement portals. Most publish openly; many send email alerts. Search "janitorial", "custodial", "building services".
Fresh for	Until the deadline — check it first, it is often short
Record as	<i>RFP 2026-114, custodial services, Northside ISD, posted 12 Aug, closes 6 Sept</i>

Why almost nobody uses it: it looks like paperwork. It is the strongest signal available.

Verify before you spend an hour on it

Public bids reward preparation and punish improvisation. Check these in order and stop at the first one that rules you out:

1. **Is it current?** Portals keep expired notices visible. Confirm the closing date.
2. **When does it close?** Many give two to four weeks. If it closes Friday and you have not started, it is not for you.
3. **Can you bid at all?** Vendor registration, bonding, insurance minimums, business licensing, and sometimes a minimum number of years trading or comparable contracts. Some require certifications you cannot get in time.
4. **Prevailing wage?** Many public contracts require it. It changes your labour cost completely, and a bid priced at your normal rates will lose money if you win it.
5. **What is the actual scope?** Square footage, frequency, specialty work, day porter, supplies. Read the whole document — the scope is often larger than the title suggests.
6. **Is there a mandatory walkthrough?** Frequently yes, and missing it disqualifies you.
7. **Is the incumbent bidding?** Usually. Public records often show the current contract value — which tells you the price to beat, and whether it is worth beating.

The honest warning: public cleaning contracts are often price-driven and lower margin than private work, and the paperwork is real. A fair number are not worth winning. Verify first, bid second, and be willing to walk away at step 4.

2. RFP for related facility services

Grounds, maintenance or facility services going out to bid at a site.

Where	The same portals
Fresh for	Until the deadline

Why it counts	A site reviewing one vendor category often reviews others. Weaker than a cleaning RFP, stronger than any inference.
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Tier 2 · Facility events

A building changed in a way that creates a cleaning need. Strong, but you are inferring the need — they have not said it.

3. New facility or first occupancy

Where	Occupancy and tenant-improvement permits on your county or city portal
Fresh for	90 days
Record as	<i>TI permit #2026-04412 finalized 2 Aug, City of Plano</i>

No incumbent to displace. A first purchase, not a switch.

4. New location opened

Where	A new Google Business listing under an existing brand · "now open" notices · local press
Fresh for	120 days

5. Move or relocation

Where	Address change on their Google listing · "we've moved" notices · business-journal columns
Fresh for	90 days
Why it lands	They are buying everything at once and want it off the list

6. New commercial lease signed

A listing flips from available to leased.

Where	Commercial property listing sites. Check the same handful weekly and note what changed.
Fresh for	90 days
Why it is useful	Often 30–60 days ahead of the occupancy permit, so you arrive early

7. Suite expansion

They took the unit next door.

Where	Listing changes · updated square footage · a second suite number appearing
Fresh for	90 days
Why it is easy to win	Their current cleaner is priced for the old footprint, and someone has to reprice it

8. Competitor cleaning company closing or sold

Their accounts need a vendor.

Where	A Google listing going "permanently closed" · a business-for-sale listing · local talk
Fresh for	90 days

Handle this carefully. Approach the *buildings*, not the competitor's staff or client list, and never mention the competitor by name. This industry is small and it will get back to people.

9. Post-construction completion

Where	The permit portal, filtered to finalized commercial permits
Fresh for	60 days
Note	Post-construction cleaning is a separate, usually larger, one-off job. Price it separately.

Tier 3 · Organizational events

Something changed at the organization. Vendors may come up for review. May.

10. Property management change

Where	Portfolio pages on management company sites · listing sites · signage
Fresh for	90 days
Why it is worth the most per conversation	New managers review inherited vendors, and one relationship can cover several buildings

11. Building sold or changed owner

Where	County property records, searchable in most counties
Fresh for	120 days
Why	New owners review operating costs, and cleaning is an easy line to look at

12. Facilities or operations hiring

Where	Indeed and LinkedIn — Facilities Manager, Office Manager, Operations Manager
Fresh for	90 days

Two-edged. They may review vendors, or be too new to change anything for six months.

13. Renovation or reopening

Where	Renovation permits · reopening announcements · temporary closure on their listing
Fresh for	60 days

14. Acquisition, new business licence, or sign permit

Three routes to the same conclusion: something new is operating at an address.

Where	Business journals and registries · city business-licence records · sign permits on the same portal as occupancy
Fresh for	90–120 days
Note	A sign permit is often the earliest public signal a new tenant exists, and it is cheap to check

15. New provider or partner joining a practice

Where	Staff pages on medical and dental sites
Fresh for	90 days
Why	More chairs, more rooms in use, more cleaning

Tier 4 · Secondary signals

Activity, not evidence of a cleaning need. Use to break a tie between accounts that already have a Tier 1–3 trigger.

16. Headcount growth · funding · reopening · seasonal · review mentions

A company that raised money has more money. It does not have a dirtier office.

Seasonal is the exception worth planning around: schools and childcare before term and before the summer break. Not an event, but a real window, and the only one you can diary a year ahead.

Review mentions cleaning — why this is Tier 4 and not Tier 1

It feels like the strongest signal in the library. It isn't.

A review saying the restrooms were filthy does not tell you the business controls the cleaning contract, that the reviewer was an employee rather than a customer, that the problem is current, or that anyone is looking. It is an inference about dissatisfaction, not an observation of a buying window.

Never quote a review to a prospect. It reads as surveillance, and it asserts something about their vendor you cannot support.

What you may and may not say

You observed	You may say	You may not say
A published cleaning RFP	"Saw the custodial solicitation — are you taking bids from new vendors?"	Anything about the incumbent
Occupancy permit	"Saw the new building on Commerce cleared occupancy"	"You don't have a cleaner yet"
New Google listing	"Saw you opened the second location"	"You'll need a cleaner there"
Address change	"Noticed you moved to Commerce Street"	"Your old cleaner won't follow you"
Building sold	"Saw the building changed hands in July"	"The new owners will want to cut costs"
Portfolio addition	"Saw you picked up the Elm Street building"	"The inherited vendor won't work out"
Facilities job post	"Saw you're hiring a facilities manager"	"They'll want to replace their vendors"
Competitor closed	"I understand you may be looking for a new cleaning provider"	The competitor's name, or why they closed
Review complaint	<i>nothing</i>	<i>anything</i>

Everything in the right column is a conclusion.

Checking weekly — about 40 minutes

Check	Where	How often
Procurement portals	State, county, school district	Weekly, and set up email alerts
Permits — occupancy, TI, sign, renovation	County or city portal	Weekly
Listing changes on your accounts	Google Business	Weekly
Facilities and ops job posts	Indeed, LinkedIn	Weekly
Commercial lease listings	CRE sites	Weekly
Management company portfolios	Their websites	Fortnightly
Property sales	County records	Fortnightly
Business journal	Local press	Fortnightly

Set the procurement alerts first. It is the only source on this list that emails you when a building decides to buy.

Freshness is the whole advantage. A 120-day-old permit is history, and mentioning it reads as careless. Work the newest first.